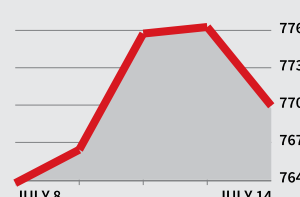


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77054.94 (-561.46)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24052.05	-158.95
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.89	-0.17
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.20	+0.58
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	141314.00	-305
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	219975.00	+1253

TOXIC HERBICIDE.

A draft government order proposes a blanket ban on Paraquat Dichloride, citing its toxicity to humans and animals **p10**



BANKING REFORM.

RBI to usher in principle-based framework for banks as part of governance overhaul **p8**

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QUICKLY.

BANKERS' MEET

RBI pushes for FCNR(B) deposits, credit growth



Mumbai/Chennai: The Reserve Bank of India used its latest interaction with bank chief executives to push lenders on four areas — strengthening fraud detection mechanisms to tackle mule accounts, accelerating credit growth beyond financial inclusion, improving mobilisation of FCNR(B) deposits, and examining a relaxation in gold loan norms. **p8**

PRICEY FOOD, FUEL

Wholesale inflation in June surges to 9.9%

New Delhi: With the rise in fuel and food prices, wholesale inflation based on the WPI rose further to 9.9 per cent in June from 9.7 per cent in May. At the same time, the output Producer Price Index inflation rose to 9.6 per cent from 9.4 per cent in May. “Across groups, ‘mineral oils’, ‘food articles’, ‘manufacture of basic metals’, and ‘manufacture of chemicals and chemical products’, have been major drivers of WPI inflation in June,” an official statement said. **p3**

New Services Index out; 14 sub-sectors grow strongly

COMING SOON. Work underway to compile ISP for health & residential care, education

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

The government on Tuesday unveiled the trial Index of Services Production (ISP), a new high-frequency indicator that showed formal services activity remained resilient in April despite the West Asia conflict, with 14 of the 19 sub-sectors tracked recording double-digit growth over the previous year.

The inaugural monthly series, with 2024-25 as the base year, covers 19 sub-sectors, including wholesale and retail trade, accommodation and food services, road and air transport, telecommunications and banking, which together account for around 60 per cent of India's services sector.

ISP FOR SUB-SECTORS

The services sector contributes more than half of the country's gross value added (GVA). With the launch of ISP, all three broad sectors of the economy — services, industry and agriculture — will now have regular monthly or quarterly production indic-



TAKING STOCK. V Anantha Nageswaran, CEA, with Saurabh Garg (right), Secretary, MoSP, at a press meet in New Delhi SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

ators. Dalip Singh, Additional Director-General, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, said work is on to compile the ISP for sub-sectors such as health and residential care, education and ownership of dwellings using administrative data, with the aim of expanding coverage to more than 80 per cent of services activity.

He said the April data reflects the impact of the West Asia conflict.

“The new series will help put the services sector on the same footing as industrial production data,” Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran said at a media briefing in New Delhi.

Releasing the trial series would ensure the dataset is

tested and validated by users before it is transformed into a regular index, he added.

He said the new index would help policymakers identify slowdowns in the services sector much sooner. “When a sector slows, we would like to know within weeks and not after months. Services Production Index does just that,” he said.

Nageswaran said that while the ISP measures production volumes, the underlying data are reported in value terms and, therefore, depend on appropriate deflation. He added that the coverage of the index would be expanded over time.

‘HOME’ TOPS

The first set of data showed accommodation and food

services recorded the highest annual growth at 37.2 per cent in April, followed by retail trade (30.8 per cent), administrative and support services (28.7 per cent) and real estate activities (27.7 per cent).

Transport was the weakest-performing segment, with air transport contracting 13.9 per cent and rail transport declining 0.4 per cent to an index level of 99.59. Higher fuel prices and geopolitical uncertainty may have weighed on this activity.

According to the Ministry, the ISP uses a differentiated approach for compiling sub-sector indices based on the nature and availability of data, drawing primarily on administrative data, GST numbers and the Annual Survey of Incorporated Services Sector Enterprises.

The Ministry said the ISP currently covers only formal sector enterprises because it is based on GST and administrative data.

The Ministry added that the ISP will be released on the 29th of every month, with future revisions and expansion in coverage as more data sources become available.

Exporters upbeat on UK market as FTA goes live today

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Indian exporters, especially in labour-intensive sectors such as apparel, leather, footwear and textiles, are reporting a surge in enquiries from British buyers ahead of the implementation of the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement on July 15, as brands move to capitalise on duty-free access for Indian products.

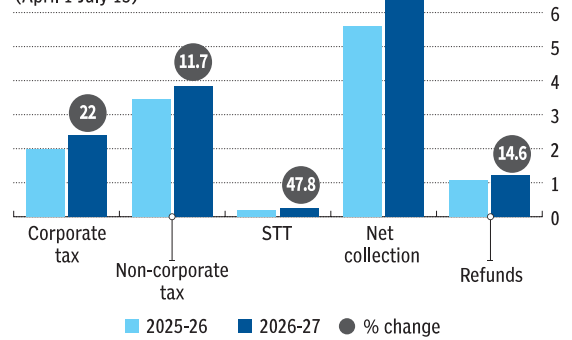
Exporters said the removal of tariffs on most products would boost India's competitiveness in the UK, placing it on a par with rivals such as Bangladesh and Vietnam while giving it an edge over suppliers such as China, which do not enjoy similar preferential access.

“The apparel industry is fully geared to make the most of duty-free access to the UK market,” said Mithileshwar Thakur, Secretary-General, AEPF.

Details p7

Net direct tax collections

(April 1-July 13)



Source: Income Tax India

show a healthy increase driven by higher volumes traded due to the volatility in the stock market.”

According to Hitesh Sawhney, Partner, Price Waterhouse & Co, non-corporate tax collections have also maintained a healthy momentum. “Gross non-corporate tax collections are up 15.02 per cent and net collections have grown 11.66 per cent, indicating increased compliance. STT collections continue to be particularly buoyant, rising 47.85 per cent, supported by strong market activity and the revised STT rates on futures and options,” he said.

Significantly, net corporate tax collections have already reached around 19.5 per cent of the Budget Estimates, while net non-corporate tax collections stand at 27.6 per cent. “This is a good and encouraging close to the first quarter, with three more quarters still ahead,” he said.

It may be noted that non-corporate taxpayers include taxes paid by individuals, HUFs, firms, AoPs, BoIs,

local authorities and artificial juridical person.

GROWTH DRIVERS

Jayesh Sanghvi, Tax Partner at EY India, said the notable feature of the current trend is the stronger growth in corporate tax collections relative to personal income tax collections and healthy advance tax payments by corporates. At the same time, robust personal income tax collections point to continued improvements in compliance and formalisation, while the sharp increase in STT collections signals continued capital market depth and investor participation, despite geopolitical risk premiums weighing on global portfolios.

“Looking ahead, the data suggest that while the Strait of Hormuz tensions, tariff uncertainty, and oil price volatility may continue to cap headline GDP growth expectations, India's fiscal engine is proving structurally more resilient than the macro headlines suggest,” he said.

₹ breaches 96/\$ as oil rises on Gulf escalation

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

The rupee on Tuesday breached the psychologically crucial 96 mark to the US dollar, giving up almost all the gains it made after the government and the Reserve Bank of India made a series of announcements to attract foreign capital in early June.

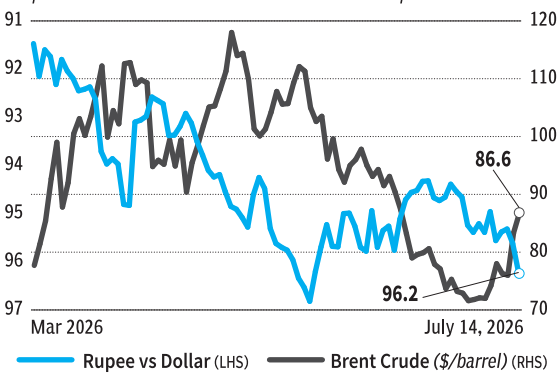
The rupee's fall came as US President Donald Trump intensified military operations against Iran, triggering a sharp rise in global crude oil prices and adding pressure on oil-importing economies such as India. Higher crude prices India's import bill and drives up the demand for dollars, putting downward pressure on the rupee.

The Indian currency, which opened weaker at 95.94, tumbled 58 paise to close at 96.20 per dollar against the previous close of 95.62. In intra-day trade, it tested a low of 96.24/\$.

The rupee last breached

Rupee vs Crude: Perfect symphony

Rupee rises and falls in tune with Brent crude price



Source: Bloomberg

the 96/dollar mark in May. On May 20, it opened around 96.86, touched an all-time intra-day low of 96.96, and closed at 96.82, the weakest closing level on record.

SENTIMENT OUTWEIGHS

V Rama Chandra Reddy, Head of Treasury, Karur Vysya Bank, said: “The primary driver for the rupee's weakness is the escalation in the West Asia conflict.

This sharply lifted crude oil prices and weakened sentiment across emerging market currencies. Market sentiment currently outweighs the positive impact of inflows on account of FCNR (B) deposits and investment by FPIs under the fully accessible route.”

He said that crude oil had declined to around \$70 a barrel in early July but had since rebounded to around \$85-86

as geopolitical tensions intensify.

The spike in crude prices has amplified concerns over India's current account deficit and increased dollar demand from oil importers, both of which weighed on the rupee.

Rising oil prices are a negative for India because they increase the country's import bill and demand for dollars.

G-SECS FEEL THE HEAT

Separately, the government securities market, too, felt the heat of rising crude oil prices, a pick-up in retail inflation and hardening US Treasury yields.

Yield of the 10-year benchmark G-Sec (6.94 per cent GS 2036) rose about 6 basis points to close at 6.7945 per cent against the previous close of 6.73 per cent.

Price of this security was down 40 paise. Yield and price of a bond are inversely correlated and move in opposite directions.

After six decades, the Indian Grey Hornbill makes home in Gir

Birds re-introduced in Gujarat's famed Asiatic lion habitat in 2021 have bred successfully for four years

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

It's a winged comeback story that is a major ecological triumph. Sixty years after the Indian Grey Hornbill disappeared from the forests of Gir, largely due to hunting pressures, the arboreal bird with a grey cloak and distinctive curved beak is back again in one of India's most celebrated forest ecosystems that is also home to the Asiatic lion.

ALIVE & THRIVING

A new peer-reviewed study has found that hornbills re-introduced in Gir in 2021 have not only survived but have also established territories, adapted to the landscape and bred successfully



GREEN GUARDIANS. The return of the species has immense ecological significance as the fruit-loving birds are important long-distance seed dispersers.

for four consecutive years, marking one of India's most promising bird reintroduction efforts. The findings, published in the international journal *Birds*, offer the first detailed assessment of the Gujarat Forest Department's programme to restore the species to Gir after its disappearance six decades ago.

Arjun Modhwadia, Minister for Forests and Environment, Government of Gujarat, termed the research findings a major success for the re-introduction programme. The project involved the phased release of 40 Indian Grey Hornbills.

Twenty-eight birds were released between 2021 and 2022, followed by another

12 in 2023. The birds were translocated from healthy populations in Gujarat's Aravalli forests after scientists concluded that decades of habitat protection had once again made Gir suitable for the species.

FINDING NESTS

To understand how the birds adapted, researchers fitted 11 males with satellite transmitters and monitored their movements, habitat preferences and breeding behaviour over several years. The tracking data showed a familiar pattern seen in many wildlife re-introductions.

Newly-released hornbills initially ranged widely across unfamiliar landscapes, occupying an aver-

age home range of nearly 61 sq km. As they became familiar with their surroundings, that range contracted sharply to around 5.7 sq km.

Daily movement also declined considerably — from an average of 4.3 km during the exploratory phase to about 1.4 km after settlement — indicating that the birds had established stable territories.

The return of the species has immense ecological significance as the fruit-loving Indian Grey Hornbills are important long-distance seed dispersers. Feeding largely on fruits such as banyan, *peepal*, *karamda* and *dhraman*, they transport these seeds across wide areas, helping regenerate native forests naturally.

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QUICKLY.

Renault launches Duster Adventure Edition



Chennai: Renault India, the wholly-owned subsidiary of the Renault Group, launched the Renault Duster Adventure Edition, a special edition of its iconic SUV, on Tuesday with prices starting at ₹12.99 lakh (ex-showroom). Available in Turbo TcE 100 MT, Turbo TcE 160 MT and Turbo TcE 160 DCT powertrain options, the Adventure Edition introduces distinctive exterior elements that celebrate Duster's adventure heritage. **OUR BUREAU**

Sigma Advanced Systems bays UK-based firm

Hyderabad: Sigma Advanced Systems, an aerospace precision engineering company, acquired 100 per cent equity share capital of the UK-based Bromford Precision Solutions, a specialist manufacturer of high-precision, complex aero-engine rings and other engine structures. The transaction, valued at approximately £11.89 million (about ₹153 crore), is expected to close by the end of July. **OUR BUREAU**

Ikea India aims to quadruple sales by 2030 on the back of accelerated retail expansion

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani New Delhi

Ikea India aims to quadruple its sales by 2030 and said it is witnessing strong double-digit growth as it accelerates its retail expansion plans. Earlier this year, the Swedish furniture and home furnishings major, which has invested over ₹10,500 crore in India so far, said it plans to more than double its investments by 2030. Patrik Antoni, CEO, Ikea India, told *businessline*, “We are witnessing a double-digit growth trajectory with growth in sales and store visitations. India is a key growth market for us from the long-term perspective. We are quite bullish on the market with its large base of consumers, a growing economy and rapid urbanisation.” He added, “We are aiming to quadruple our sales by 2030 to about ₹8,000 crore.

Hero MotoCorp unveils long-term growth blueprint

TECH-DRIVEN ROADMAP. Key focus on premiumisation, AI and global expansion

Amit Vijay Mohile Mumbai

Hero MotoCorp Chairman Pawan Munjal and CEO Harshavardhan Chitale have used the company's FY26 annual report to unveil a long-term growth blueprint centred on premiumisation, technology, connected mobility, artificial intelligence (AI) and global expansion, offering shareholders the clearest roadmap yet for the next phase of growth at the country's largest two-wheeler manufacturer. Hero MotoCorp's next chapter will be driven as much by technology, software, premium products and international markets as by motorcycles themselves, according to Munjal and Chitale. Rather than focusing primarily on volumes, market share or individual product launches, they describe a company preparing for fundamental shifts in mobility through investments in AI, connected vehicle platforms, multiple low-emission powertrains, digital manufacturing, premiumisation and global expansion. The strategy provides the broader framework under-



GRAND VISION. The company will evolve from being a volume-driven motorcycle maker towards a broader mobility ecosystem powered by technology and digital capabilities

pinning Hero's future product and investment plans. **MOBILITY ENTERPRISE** Munjal's message to shareholders centres on redefining Hero's identity. “Our journey began with a singular mission — to democratise mobility for millions. Today, we are evolving into a diversified mobility and technology enterprise.” He highlighted investments across electric mobility, connected ecosystems, premium segments, advanced R&D, digital platforms, intelligent manufacturing, global partnerships and sustainable operations. The vision marks a significant evolution from Hero's traditional positioning as a volume-driven motorcycle manufacturer toward becoming a broader mobility

ecosystem powered by technology and digital capabilities. The annual report reinforces this transformation through Hero's Connected Vehicle Platform, which manages the entire vehicle and customer lifecycle — from production to end-of-life — using connected technologies and over-the-air software updates. This enables the company to maintain engagement with customers long after the initial sale. **CONNECTED TECH** While Hero continues to expand its electric mobility portfolio, Chitale's letter suggested the company is deliberately avoiding an EV-only strategy. Instead, he emphasised investments in connected technologies, digital capabilities and mul-

tiples low-emission powertrains, signalling a technology-agnostic approach as consumer preferences and regulatory frameworks continue to evolve. “We remain focused on strengthening our core business, accelerating growth in premium and electric mobility, expanding our global footprint and building a more agile, future-ready organisation,” Chitale said. The strategy focuses on reinforcing Hero's existing motorcycle business while simultaneously creating new growth engines in premium mobility, exports and digital capabilities, rather than replacing one business with another.

CAPABILITIES FIRST A recurring theme in both shareholder letters is the belief that future competitiveness will depend less on manufacturing scale alone and more on organisational capabilities. AI, digital engineering, resilient supply chains, intelligent manufacturing, software platforms and faster product development feature prominently throughout the report as the capabilities Hero believes will define success in the coming decade.

MRF is India's most valuable and strongest tyre brand

Our Bureau Chennai

MRF Tyres, the Chennai-based tyre manufacturer, has been ranked as India's Most Valuable and Strongest tyre brand. It also also features as the world's third Strongest Tyre Brand and among the Top 50 most valuable brands in India. This is across all industries, including automobiles, in the Brand Finance India 100 - 2026 report, launched on Monday. The report recognises the country's most influential and valuable brands, with the combined value of the Top 100 crossing \$236.5 billion this year, the release said. In Brand Finance's dedicated global Tyres 25 - 2026 report, MRF was named amongst the top 3 strongest tyre brands in the world, with a Brand Strength Index score of 87.7 out of 100.

L&T's infra expansion at Kattupalli to include fabrication and assembly shops

T E Raja Simhan Chennai

Larsen & Toubro (L&T), which recently signed an investment MoU with the Tamil Nadu government, has sought fresh Environmental Clearance (EC) and Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) clearance to execute the project, *businessline* has learnt. L&T has proposed a ₹1,100 crore infrastructure expansion at its Kattupalli shipyard and modular fabrication facility near Chennai to ramp up production and fully utilise the capacities already permitted under earlier environmental approvals. The expansion will include fabrication and assembly shops, warehouse sheds, a skill development centre, residential accommodation for employees, office buildings, an additional jetty and other operational infrastructure. These additions are intended to strengthen the operational capabilities of the shipyard and modular fabrication facility, sources said. According to a pre-feasibility report prepared for obtaining statutory clearances, the proposed investment will be made entirely within L&T's existing 892.11-acre complex and will not require any additional land acquisition.



PROPOSED TIMELINE. The project is expected to be implemented over three years, with development activities proposed between October 2025 and October 2028

tion or rehabilitation. The development is aimed at enabling the company to achieve its approved modular fabrication capacity of 50,000 tonnes per annum, along with annual capacities for building 25 ships and repairing 60 ships. **CAPITAL COST** The project is expected to be implemented over three years, with development activities proposed between October 2025 and October 2028. The capital cost estimate of ₹1,100 crore includes civil works, plant and machinery, engineering, contingencies and establishment costs. The report estimates employment for around 1,000 workers during the construction phase. Once operational, the expanded facility is expected to generate around 6,000 direct and indirect jobs, including contractual employment. Beyond its maritime significance, the expansion is expected to play an increasingly important role in the renewable energy supply chain. Kattupalli already serves as a key fabrication base for complex offshore structures and has emerged as an important asset in L&T's growing offshore wind business. The facility supports the manufacture of largescale offshore and onshore modules, including jackets, topsides, turbine towers and floating structures for the energy sector.

Tata Elxsi Q1 profit rises 18% to ₹170.6 crore

Press Trust of India New Delhi

Design and technology services provider Tata Elxsi reported an 18.17 per cent increase in net profit to ₹170.59 crore during Q1 of FY27, driven by growth in key verticals and strong deal execution. The company had posted a profit of ₹144.36 crore in the year-ago quarter, according to a regulatory filing. Tata Elxsi's revenue from operations rose 14.46 per cent to ₹1,021.1 crore (₹892.09 crore). “The performance in the quarter reflects the strength and increasing relevance of our design-led and AI-enabled engineering capabilities in our chosen industries,” Tata Elxsi CEO and MD Manoj Raghavan said. Its transportation business reported a 13.3 per cent rise, driven by accelerated OEM engagements and wins in the off-road and aerospace segments. OEM revenues now constitute 78 per cent of the firm's automotive revenues, Raghavan said. In its Media & Communications division, Tata Elxsi recorded a 22.2 per cent growth, driven by the scale-up of key partnerships and expanded initiatives with global operators, broadcasters and device OEMs.

Vedanta plans to invest \$5 billion for expanding oil & gas biz over 3-5 years

Press Trust of India New Delhi

Vedanta Chairman Anil Agarwal on Tuesday unveiled an ambitious growth roadmap, saying the company will nearly treble zinc and lead production, double silver output and accelerate exploration of critical and strategic minerals including lithium and rare earths, while committing \$5 billion in investments to expand its oil and gas business. Agarwal unveiled an ambitious vision for ‘Vedanta Unlimited’ at Vedanta's 61st Annual General Meeting (AGM). Speaking at the AGM, he said the company plans to nearly treble zinc and lead output to 3 million tonnes (mt) by 2031, double silver production to 1,500 tonnes, and raise copper production to 1 mt by the decade-end. He said ferrochrome capacity would be ramped up to 5 lakh tonnes by FY28 and nickel output increased to 60,000 tonnes. He added the firm would accelerate exploration across its 10 critical and strategic mineral blocks, covering lithium, cobalt, gold, copper, nickel, manganese, rare earths and potash. **PLANS ALL ACROSS** Vedanta Group reiterated

Decoding the Constitutional challenges in the delimitation math

Saurabh Suryawanshi Sourashis Banerjee Chennai

India is on the verge of its most consequential electoral redrawing in nearly 50 years. The number of Lok Sabha seats each State holds has been frozen since 1976, and the 2027 Census is set to finally unfreeze it, redistributing roughly 281 new seats across 36 States and Union Territories.

DATA FOCUS.

As per the Delimitation Bill, 2026, tabled in the Lok Sabha on April 16, the government plans to distribute the seats in a way that keeps the current proportional distribution of seats between the States intact. Or, in other words, each State and Union Territory is supposed to receive a 50 per cent increase in their seat count. However, such an arrangement contradicts one of the fundamental aspects of the Constitution — “one vote, one value,” being championed by members of the ruling polity for long.

THE DILEMMA

If the current share of each State/UT in total parliamentary seats is maintained, as put forth in the Delimitation Bill, 2026, Rajasthan will have 14 lakh voters in each constituency, Karnataka 13 lakh voters, and Bihar and Uttar Pradesh will have 12.8 lakh voters each. But States like Tamil Nadu will have an average of 10.6 lakh voters per constituency, Odisha and Uttarakhand 10.5 lakh voters per constituency and Kerala only 9 lakh voters per constituency. Consequently, one vote in Rajasthan will have far less value than a vote in Kerala. According to Prashant Bhushan, public interest lawyer in the Supreme Court of India, “The core of India's delimitation debate lies in balancing two competing principles. One is the principle of equal weight of every vote, which requires constituencies to have roughly the same number of voters so that no citizen's vote carries more weight than another's. The other is federalism, which implies that States should not lose political influence simply because they were more successful in controlling population growth.” MR Madhavan, President, PRS Legislative Research, put it simply. “Article 81(2) (a) says every State gets Lok Sabha seats in proportion to its population, and Article 81 (2)(b) says that within a State, every constituency must be equal to every other.

One vote, one value?

Variation in number of voters Delimitation plan as proposed by government, retaining States' current share in total Parliamentary seats

State / UT	Parliamentary constituencies (post-delimitation)	Voters per State in 2024 (in lakh)	Voters per constituency (in lakh)
Rajasthan	38	535	14.08
NCT of Delhi	11	152	13.82
Haryana	15	202	13.47
Karnataka	42	548	13.05
Maharashtra	72	931	12.93
Madhya Pradesh	44	567	12.89
Bihar	60	773	12.88
Uttar Pradesh	120	1544	12.87
Gujarat	39	498	12.77
Telangana	26	332	12.77
Jharkhand	21	259	12.33
Chhattisgarh	17	207	12.18
West Bengal	63	761	12.08
Assam	21	246	11.71
Jammu and Kashmir	8	88	11.00
Andhra Pradesh	38	414	10.89
Punjab	20	216	10.80
Tamil Nadu	59	624	10.58
Odisha	32	337	10.53
Uttarakhand	8	84	10.50
Kerala	30	278	9.27

■ Less value per vote ■ More value per vote

Based on equivalent representation, Rajasthan should see an almost doubling of its seat count

State / UT	Current seats (frozen since 1976 Census)	Projections based on 2011 Census*	Increase in seats
Rajasthan	25	46	21
Haryana	10	17	7
Bihar	40	69	29
Uttar Pradesh	80	133	53
Madhya Pradesh	29	48	19
NCT of Delhi	7	11	4
Jharkhand	14	22	8
Chhattisgarh	11	17	6
Maharashtra	48	75	27
Gujarat	26	40	14
Assam	14	21	7
Karnataka	28	41	13
West Bengal	42	61	19
Punjab	13	19	6
Uttarakhand	5	7	2
Andhra Pradesh**	42	56	14
Odisha	21	28	7
Jammu & Kashmir**	6	8	2
Tamil Nadu	39	48	9
Kerala	20	22	2

* Gains proportionally ■ Losses proportionally
*Total seats increased 50 per cent to account for population growth
**Andhra Pradesh refers to the undivided state, Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh are treated as a single unit for comparability with the 2011 Census.

Source: bl analysis

If you add these two, it effectively means every constituency in the country should have the same population.” That principle, however, has been suspended for half a century. “Inter-State allocation of seats is frozen at the 1971 Census, and intra-State boundaries at the 2001 Census — both until the first Census after 2026,” Madhavan said. The freeze flows from the provision to Article 81(3), introduced by the 42nd Constitutional Amendment in 1976 and extended by the 84th Amendment in 2001, based on the logic of giving

the different States of India some time to stabilise their rapidly-expanding populations. **FEDERAL LOGIC** Srinivasan Ramachandran, former Secretary and Research Officer, Government of Tamil Nadu, argued, “The whole issue is not the number of seats. It is about the proportion of seats for the States. “In a federal country, not only people should be represented, but the units of the federation should also be properly represented.”

Saurabh Suryawanshi is an intern

I-T dept places ₹4 cr penalty on Titan Company

Our Bureau Bengaluru

Titan Company on Tuesday informed the stock exchanges regarding the receipt of tax penalty orders from the Assessment Unit of the Income Tax Department. The orders were passed on June 26, alleging an “under-reporting of income” due to adjustments made to the company's tax assessment. The impacted financial years include AY2017-18 with a penalty of ₹56.67 lakh, and AY2019-20 with penalty of ₹3.7 crore, totalling about ₹4.27 crore. The company noted the delay in notifying the stock exchanges was due to an internal review and evaluation of their legal options. It is, currently, in the process of filing an appeal and has stated that the penalty has had no material impact on its operations, financials or other activities.

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Fund of relief

Latest EPF reforms address many pain points of subscribers

In a material overhaul of the Employees Provident Fund (EPF), the Centre has recently amended the provisions of EPF Scheme 1952, replacing it with a 2026 version. The new scheme substantially simplifies conditions for employees to make early withdrawals, standardises waiting periods and puts in place rules to ensure continuity of the provident fund account in the event of career interruptions or personal emergencies.



However, reforms in the EPF will remain incomplete as long as issues relating to delays and rejections continue to dog legacy subscribers filing their retirement claims. Before the recent changes, employees’ attempts to withdraw any portion of their balance before retirement age were liable to be mired in reams of red tape. Early withdrawals were allowed only under 13 situations for which the employee had to provide documentary proof, and these were subject to varying waiting periods and sub-limits. Under the new rules, the 13 conditions have been whittled down to four broader categories — marriage, education, illness and housing, with an added carve-out for special circumstances (natural calamities). Arbitrary caps on withdrawals (50 per cent of own contribution for marriage/education, 90 per cent of corpus for housing) and different waiting periods (five years for housing, seven years for marriage, among others) have been done away with. Employees can also withdraw up to 75 per cent of the total balance to their credit, irrespective of end-use. All types of withdrawals will now be allowed if the employee has completed 12 months of service, with the waiting period being waived in the event of job losses.

Some have criticised the requirement that employees must retain 25 per cent of their balances. However, this is a pragmatic check on retirement savings drain. Full withdrawals also trigger closures and reopening of new EPF accounts, leading to the proliferation of inactive accounts and unclaimed balances. While attempts to make early withdrawals more subscriber-friendly are welcome, legacy subscribers are likely to be more concerned about the prompt processing of their final claims without rent-seeking by intermediaries. The new scheme has made online mode the default option for filing final claims and set a 20-day deadline for settlement. Final settlement amounts will be electronically transferred to the beneficiary’s account. A penal interest at 12 per cent of the outstanding amount will be charged on the PF Commissioner’s personal salary, if there are delays beyond this deadline — provided ‘all requisite documents’ are submitted.

However, the rules contain several escape clauses. Penal interest is only applicable where the Commissioner fails to settle claims ‘without sufficient cause’. Given that rejections due to minor name mismatches are the main reasons for majority of claim rejections, these clauses don’t really offer much comfort to subscribers. One hopes that the ongoing digital overhaul of the EPFO addresses these problems.

POCKET



DESMOND LACHMAN

Japan appears to be on the cusp of a full-blown currency and bond-market crisis. Although the Japanese authorities spent more than \$70 billion in May to prop up the yen, the currency has slumped to a 40-year low and is estimated to be at least 15 per cent undervalued against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, Japanese long-term bond yields have surged to multi-decade highs following the end of the Bank of Japan’s yield-curve-control policy. And with no signs of Japan addressing the underlying causes of its currency’s downward spiral anytime soon, there is every reason to fear that the crisis will deepen.

Japan’s current challenges should be a wake-up call for other countries that appear to be on unsustainable public-debt paths, not least the US, as well as France, Italy, and the UK. After all, an economic and financial crisis in one country often draws the market’s attention to other countries facing similar problems. That was certainly the case with the Asian currency crisis in 1997, when a Thai currency devaluation triggered similar devaluations in Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, and South Korea.

It was also the case with the eurozone crisis in 2010, when a Greek sovereign-debt crisis triggered similar crises in Ireland, Italy, Portugal, and Spain.

UNSUSTAINABLE PUBLIC DEBT There appear to be two main drivers of Japan’s currency and bond market woes: its unsustainable public finances and its relatively low interest rates (compared to the US). At 230 per cent, Japan has by far the highest public debt-to-GDP ratio among G7 countries, and it still runs a primary budget deficit, which adds to the existing debt.

Then there is Japan’s declining and ageing population, as well as a government that has shifted from targeting a single-year primary budget surplus to a vaguer medium-term debt stabilization policy. Is it any wonder that markets are growing uneasy about the country’s public-debt trajectory?

It does not help that Sanae Takaichi, Japan’s new Prime Minister, seems uninterested in putting the country on a sounder budget footing anytime soon. Among her first economic-policy moves was to adopt a supplemental budget that



A Japanese wake-up call for America

CRISIS AHEAD. Japan’s currency and bond market woes are a result of its unsustainable public debt. The other Western nations must pay heed

increased energy subsidies in response to the shock to international oil prices from the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Japan’s large debt burden makes it difficult for the BOJ to raise interest rates even at a time when inflation appears to be accelerating.

Tightening monetary policy would only exacerbate the country’s public-finance problems by increasing interest payments. While the US Federal Reserve’s short-term interest rate is at 3.5 per cent, the BOJ’s policy interest rate is at just 1 per cent.

That spread continues to give investors an incentive to borrow cheaply in Japanese yen and lend in higher-yielding dollar-based assets (the “carry trade”).

Japan’s large debt burden makes it difficult for the BOJ to raise interest rates even at a time when inflation appears to be accelerating

This will remain the case as long as the yen continues to depreciate.

JAPAN’S OPTIONS But Herb Stein’s famous aphorism bears repeating: If something cannot go on forever, it will stop. In principle, Japan could get off its unsustainable debt path in an orderly manner if the government made a preemptive and timely economic-policy U-turn to avert a currency and bond-market crisis. Or it could do so in a disorderly manner if a full-blown currency and bond crisis forced the government’s hand.

That is what happened in the UK in 2022 in response to Prime Minister Liz Truss’s ill-advised budget measures. Unfortunately, all available signs suggest that Japan is heading in this direction.

A deepening Japanese currency and bond-market crisis is bound to draw attention to other countries with troubling public finances, and especially to the US.

At around 100 per cent, the US debt-to-GDP ratio is considerably lower than that of Japan; but the country is on track to maintain a budget deficit of

more than 6 per cent of GDP as far as the eye can see. That means its debt ratio will soon reach its highest level since the end of World War II.

Worse, additional factors are making the US more vulnerable to a bond-market crisis. Consider, for example, that foreigners own around one-third of all Treasury bonds outstanding, and that the government is increasingly reliant on hedge funds rather than on more stable bondholders (like insurance companies and pension funds) to meet its borrowing needs.

The bottom line is that highly indebted countries like the US, France, Italy, and the UK all have good reason to address their shaky public finances. The prospect of spillovers from an early Japanese currency and bond-market crisis have made the task only more urgent.

The writer is a senior fellow at the American Enterprise Institute, is a former deputy director of the International Monetary Fund’s Policy Development and Review Department and a former chief emerging-market economic strategist at Salomon Smith Barney.
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Industry-academia alignment must for growth

The future demands collaboration through co-created curricula, research programmes, and industry-based PG frameworks

Rakesh Bharti Mittal

India today stands at a defining inflection point — the challenge before us is no longer about creating jobs but building an education ecosystem that will prepare us for the future of work itself. As the global economy becomes increasingly competitive, driven by innovation, research and advanced skills, it is the strength of a nation’s industry-academia ecosystem that will define its economic leadership. India can no longer afford a higher education system where universities and industry operate in silos.

India is home to one of the world’s largest talent pools, with approximately 7-10 million young Indians entering the workforce every year. But the real opportunity lies in transforming this vast human capital into a globally competitive talent base.

That requires a fundamental shift in how academia and industry engage with each other.

India’s higher education system must evolve far more rapidly to remain aligned with industrial and technological realities.

Today, many engineering and postgraduate (PG) programmes continue to operate as legacy systems, often disconnected from evolving industry needs and emerging technologies. Industry, meanwhile, continues to invest significant time and

resources in retraining even qualified graduates. The challenge is not one of talent, but of alignment. As technological cycles shrink rapidly and future technologies such as Artificial Intelligence, Robotics, Cyber Security and Data Sciences redefine enterprise, India’s institutions must move from preparing students for “jobs in future” to preparing them for the “future of jobs”. Undergraduate education must focus on building strong foundational and interdisciplinary capabilities that prepare students for long-term adaptability across sectors, but with industry linkages. Simultaneously, postgraduate education should become far more specialised and industry aligned.

The future demands deeper collaboration through co-created curricula, joint research programmes, research labs, and industry-sponsored postgraduate pathways.

Equally important is addressing the faculty gap in instruction on emerging technologies. Greater participation from Professors of Practice and industry researchers, alongside joint faculty appointments with industry, will be essential to building globally competitive programmes.

At the same time, universities must become more agile and responsive to emerging industry realities. Ensuring curriculum revision at least every three years is critical for institutions to stay aligned with evolving industry needs and global developments.



EDUCATION. Industry-ready/ISTOCKPHOTO

Interdisciplinary learning and exposure to real-world problem solving must become central to higher education, with industry engaging on cutting-edge research and ensuring transparency in fund utilisation and outcomes. Industry, for its part, must partner with universities as co-creators of knowledge and innovation, not merely as recruiters of talent.

This is particularly critical for PG education, where low enrolment reflects limited industry relevance. Universities need to realign these programmes with sectors in demand, freeing up infrastructure and faculty capacity for more relevant postgraduate offerings.

HYBRID PATHWAYS We must also recognise that the future of learning also cannot remain confined to rigid, full-time structures. A considerable portion of young Indians enter the workforce early due to economic realities, even as technological disruption makes lifelong

learning essential. Flexible, credit-based systems, online and hybrid pathways, and multiple entry-exit options can democratise access to higher education while enabling professionals to learn and upskill throughout their careers.

India’s National Education Policy, 2020 introduced important reforms, particularly its flexible entry-exit framework, which needs to be strengthened. Globally, the most successful innovation ecosystems have emerged from strong industry-academia collaboration. India must seize this opportunity to create a similar ecosystem at scale.

The government can play a catalytic role by incentivising collaborative research, enabling matching grants for industry-led innovation, and broadening National Research Foundation (NRF) support to private universities undertaking serious research, while creating frameworks for deeper mobility between academia and industry.

Beyond strengthening higher education institutions, these reforms are about building a future-ready national ecosystem where education, research, skilling and industry evolve in tandem. Translating our demographic dividend into gains will require an adaptable and globally connected talent dividend. It is systems that align education, research, skilling and industry fastest that will define the next era of economic leadership.

The writer is Vice-Chairman, Bharti Enterprises

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Fruitful visit This refers to the Editorial ‘Beyond commerce’ (July 14). Including gains from New Zealand (shift to broader Strategic Partnership, maritime/defence cooperation and opening new channels for talent, education and investment) the composite gains for India from the Prime Minister’s visit to Indo-Pacific triangle of NZ, Australia and Indonesia are: shift from trade to trade plus security; diplomatic partners across the Indo-Pacific arc; access to critical resources; offsetting China without confrontation and one more step towards global south leadership. Many of the decisions are intentions or directional. Much will depend on how earnestly the

four nations act on them.
YG Chouksey
Pune

Strategic balancing Apropos ‘Beyond commerce’ (July 14), India’s recent Pacific tour signals a quiet but decisive shift from talking about “Look East” to actually acting on it, with Indonesia’s support for Sabang Port development and missile deals, Australia’s uranium supply, and a growing network of defence partnerships that together extend India’s maritime presence right into China’s neighbourhood. What makes this significant is not confrontation but presence; India is not joining military alliances or declaring itself anti-China, but it is steadily building relationships that protect its interests and preserve a

rules-based order in the Indo-Pacific. China will read these moves as balancing, and India should not pretend otherwise, but the real challenge now is sustaining this momentum with consistent engagement, budgets, and follow-through, because partnerships announced in communiqués must survive the test of bureaucratic inertia and shifting political priorities.
K Chidanand Kumar
Bengaluru

Attract FDI Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman has exhorted public sector banks to step up their outreach to Non-resident Indians (NRIs) to sustain the momentum in foreign currency inflows (July 14).

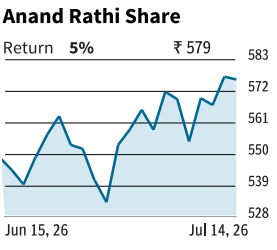
The government must also attract more FDI. Foreign portfolio investments can increase the nation’s foreign exchange earnings, but not jobs. Given the challenges posed by AI, India needs FDI to tap its labour potential.
S Ramakrishnasayee
Chennai

HDFC saga This refers to the article ‘An inexplicable resignation and collateral damage’ (July 14). The resignation of Atanu Chakraborty, former Non-Executive Chairman and Independent Director of HDFC Bank, has raised serious concerns. Reports suggesting that independent legal reviews did not substantiate the allegations make the episode difficult

to reconcile. Irrespective of the merits, the controversy has reportedly caused significant reputational damage to HDFC Bank and a sharp erosion in its market capitalisation, resulting in substantial losses for investors. If internal disagreements among senior executives contributed to this outcome, it is a matter of concern. To restore investor confidence, Chakraborty should clarify his position. If there is evidence of violation of securities laws or disclosure norms, SEBI should examine the matter and take action. A transparent resolution would strengthen confidence in corporate governance and protect investors’ interests.
Srinivasan Velamuri
Arizona (USA)

QUICKLY.

Anand Rathi Share Q1 net profit rises marginally



Bengaluru: Anand Rathi Share and Stock Brokers reported a consolidated profit after tax of ₹23.35 crore for the quarter ended June 2026, compared with ₹22.81 crore in the corresponding quarter last year. Total revenue from operations rose 22.37 per cent y-o-y to ₹246.10 crore in Q1 FY27 from ₹201.1 crore in the year-ago period. Pradeep Gupta, Chairman and Managing Director, said the company delivered a strong quarterly performance despite geopolitical uncertainty, market volatility and regulatory recalibration during the quarter. **OUR BUREAU**

Saurashtra Cement gets exempted from open offer

New Delhi: SEBI on Tuesday exempted the Mehta Family Trust, held by Bollywood actor Juhi Chawla and industrialist Jay Mehta, from making an open offer for the proposed indirect acquisition of shares and voting rights in Saurashtra Cement Ltd. The proposed transaction involves Jay Mahendra Mehta transferring his 49.99 per cent stake in Galaxy Technologies Pvt Ltd to the trust. Juhi Chawla Mehta will also transfer her 50.04 per cent profit sharing/voting rights in Omma Enterprises LLP to the trust. SEBI granted an exemption after observing that the transaction is part of an internal reorganisation of the promoter family aimed at streamlining succession planning and consolidating family holdings. **PTI**

Groww gains ground as NSE active client base rises in H1

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The broking industry added a modest 2.8 lakh active investors in the first half of 2026, bringing the total active client base on the National Stock Exchange to approximately 4.54 crore, according to NSE data.

Groww dominated the period, adding 5.7 lakh active clients, more than double the industry's net addition, to take its base from 1.24 crore to 1.3 crore. Its NSE market share climbed from 27.7 per cent in January to 28.7 per cent in June, the largest gain among leading brokers, signalling that its growth came primarily from capturing clients away from rivals rather than from new entries.

The numbers were less flattering for other discount brokers. Zerodha's active client base slipped from 68.6 lakh to 68 lakh, Angel One declined from 67.5 lakh to 66.3 lakh, and Upstox fell

Dalal Street comes under pressure as W. Asia tensions hit crude oil, Re hard

TRAMPLED. Rate-sensitive sectors such as realty, PSBs and auto bear the brunt in broad-based selling

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets snapped a three-session winning streak on Tuesday as escalating tensions in West Asia sent Brent crude prices surging past \$85 per barrel and weakening the rupee by 58 paise, rattling investor sentiment and triggering broad-based selling across rate-sensitive and consumption-driven sectors.

Adding to the unease, attacks on two commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz brought the conflict uncomfortably close to home.

The rupee had a rough session too, depreciating 58 paise to close at 96.20 against the US dollar, underperforming most Asian peers.

“Attacks on two commercial vessels in the Strait of Hormuz left one Indian seafarer dead and several others injured... Crude reacted instantly, touching near \$85. The question now being asked is whether \$100 is back in play,” said Sarvam Goel, Founder, Pocketful. The Nifty 50 closed at 24,052, down 158 points, while the BSE Sensex settled at 77,054, shedding 561 points. Both indices opened sharply lower and largely stayed under pressure through the session, ending at near the day's lows. The weekly derivatives expiry added to intra-day volatility.

SECTORAL TRENDS
Selling was broad-based. realty, PSBs and auto were the hardest-hit sectors, weighed down by elevated crude



DOWNBEAT. Market breadth was firmly negative, with as many as 379 stocks in the Nifty 500 universe closing in the red

prices and inflation concerns. Pharma and Healthcare held firm, drawing defensive buying, while Metal stocks also closed higher on commodity strength. Broader markets bore the brunt more sharply. The Nifty Midcap 100 fell 0.44 per cent while the Nifty Smallcap 100 dropped 1.01

per cent. The Market breadth was firmly negative, with as many as 379 stocks in the Nifty 500 universe closing in the red. On the macro front, retail inflation climbed to 4.4 per cent year-on-year in June from 3.9 per cent in May, breaching the RBI's 4 per cent target for the first time

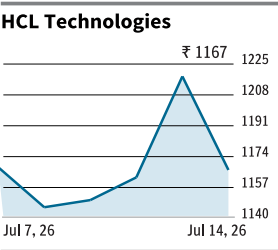
HCLTech declines on unchanged guidance

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

HCL Technologies shares declined 4.46 per cent to ₹1,166.70 on the NSE on Tuesday after the company reported its Q1 earnings.

The company retained its FY27 margin guidance, signalling continued uncertainty in client spending and slower recovery, while brokerages remained divided on the company's outlook.

The company reported a consolidated net profit of ₹4,624 crore for the first quarter ended June 30. Management retained its FY27 revenue growth guidance of 1-4 per cent on an organic constant currency basis, ex-



cluding acquisitions such as JasperSoft.

BROKERAGES DIVIDE
Domestic brokerage Motilal Oswal said client-specific issues in key verticals such as telecom had reduced the company's growth premium in FY27 estimates, although a potentially strong exit and continued deal wins could restore the gap in FY28 es-

timates. Motilal Oswal reiterated its 'Buy' rating and raised its target price to ₹1,450, while maintaining HCL Technologies as its preferred pick among large-cap IT companies.

Nomura maintained its 'Buy' rating and increased its target price to ₹1,290 from ₹1,250, saying margin normalisation was likely in FY27 and raised its FY27-28 EPS estimates by around 2-3 per cent to reflect the Q1 results and the closure of the JasperSoft acquisition.

Morgan Stanley maintained its 'Equal-weight' rating and raised its target price to ₹1,152 from ₹1,105. The brokerage said strong execution was reflected in advanced AI revenues and that

the pipeline remained robust. However, it added that macro uncertainty continued to limit confidence in a growth inflection and warned that a lack of consensus upgrades and strong recent outperformance could lead to near-term underperformance.

JPMorgan maintained its 'Underweight' on HCL Technologies but raised its target price to ₹1,060 from ₹1,000. The brokerage said that both revenue growth and margin guidance for FY27 were maintained and increased its earnings estimates by 4-6 per cent over FY27-29 due to margin upgrades.

Kotak Securities maintained its 'Reduce' rating with a target price of ₹1,200.

BROKER'S CALL.

Axis Securities

ELECON ENGINEERING (BUY)

Target: ₹600
CMP: ₹486.95
Elecon's record consolidated order-book of ₹1,518 crore (+37 per cent year-on-year) and robust order-inflow of ₹755 crore (+23 per cent) provide strong revenue visibility over the long term. The healthy order-backlog across both the Gear and Material Handling Equipment (MHE) segments is expected to support sustained execution despite a temporary slowdown in project conversion during Q1FY27. We believe the robust order pipeline, coupled with healthy enquiry levels across domestic and international markets, positions the company well for sustained long-term revenue growth. Exports continued to outperform domestic markets during the quarter. Overseas revenue grew 21.9 per cent to ₹151 crore and now contributes 29 per cent of consolidated revenue versus 25 per cent a year ago. The improvement was largely driven by stronger execution across European subsidiaries and healthy demand across global industrial markets. The management remains optimistic that improving global enquiries, strengthening overseas subsidiaries and increasing contribution from engineered products will continue to support export-led growth over the medium term. Acknowledging the ongoing macroeconomic uncertainties and near-term feasibility constraints, the management has provided conservative guidance of low double-digit consolidated revenue growth for FY27. Medium-to-long-term guidance remains highly optimistic; Elecon targets ₹5,000 crore in top-line revenue by FY30, supported by marine orders and export expansions.

Choice Institutional Equities

BAJAJ CONSUMER CARE (ADD)

Target: ₹715
CMP: ₹591
Bajaj Consumer Care's Q1FY27 results were ahead of expectation; while revenue came in line with estimate, led by continued strong momentum in ADHO (Almond Drop Hair Oil) portfolio (volume growth est. 11-12 per cent) driven by strong growth in sachets. EBITDA margin was ahead of expectation on the strength of better gross margin expansion (price hike), cost savings to the tune of 600 bps year on year and operating leverage. Q2FY27 gross margin is expected to remain under pressure as compared to Q1, on account of higher raw material cost. However, Q3 and Q4 are expected to see recovery as recent raw material price trend saw a decline. Moreover, the current EBITDA margin of 24.4 per cent is on the upper end of guided range; while long-term EBITDA margin guidance is expected to be in low to mid 20s range. We remain constructive on Bajaj Consumer Care's long-term growth strategy. Sustained double-digit growth, an improving product mix and operating leverage are expected to drive Revenue/EBITDA/PAT CAGR of 14 per cent/20 per cent/20 per cent, respectively, over FY26-29E. We have revised our one-year DCF-based TP to ₹715 (earlier: ₹690). Given the sharp appreciation in the stock price, up about 88 per cent since April 2026 (about 25 per cent since our initiating coverage) and the limited upside from the current level, we have changed our rating on the stock from Buy to 'Add'.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

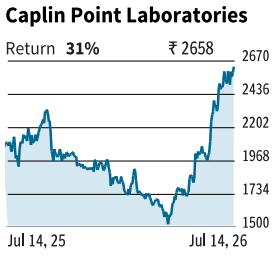
TODAY'S PICK.

Caplin Point Laboratories (₹2,658.05): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Caplin Point Laboratories. The stock has been consolidating within its broader uptrend for more than two weeks between ₹2,500 and ₹2,700.

We expect the stock to make a bullish breakout above ₹2,700 and resume the broader uptrend. Such a break could take the share price up to ₹2,900 in the short term. Traders can buy Caplin Point Laboratories shares now at ₹2,658. Accumulate on dips at ₹2,580. Keep the stop-loss at ₹2,480. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹2,695 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹2,730. Revise the



stop-loss higher to ₹2,740 and ₹2,830 when the price touches ₹2,790 and ₹2,860 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹2,900. This bullish view will go wrong only if the stock breaks below ₹2,500. But that looks less likely.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24022» Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23930	23840	24050	24175	Take fresh shorts now. Stop-loss can be kept at 24080

₹808» HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
806	800	812	816	Take fresh shorts below 806 with a stop-loss at 808

₹1092» Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1080	1065	1120	1155	Wait for dips. Go long at 1085 with a stop-loss at 1075

₹275» ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
272	269	276	280	Take fresh shorts now. Stop-loss can be placed at 277

₹248» ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
246	244	252	255	Go long now and at 247. Stop-loss can be kept at 245

₹1295» Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1285	1270	1310	1330	Go short only below 1285. Keep the stop-loss at 1290

₹1013» SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1005	990	1020	1030	Go long on a bounce from 1005 with a stop-loss at 998

₹2197» TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2175	2145	2210	2230	Go short on a break below 2175. Keep the stop-loss at 2185

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

SBI Funds Management IPO subscribed 0.68x on Day 1

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The ₹9,795-crore initial public offering of SBI Funds Management was subscribed 0.68 times or 68 per cent on the first day of bidding.

The non-institutional investors' portion was subscribed 1.39 times, while the retail investors' category saw subscription of 0.62 times. The employee portion was booked 1.02 times, and the shareholders' segment was subscribed 1.04 times. The qualified institutional buyers' portion received bids for 0.08 times.

ANCHOR BOOK

Ahead of the issue opening, SBI Funds Management raised ₹2,663 crore from anchor investors, attracting participation from global and domestic institutional investors. The anchor book included global investors such as GIC, Abu Dhabi In-

vestment Authority, Capital World Investors, BlackRock, Fidelity Management & Research, Goldman Sachs Asset Management and Norges Bank. Domestic participants included Life Insurance Corporation of India, HDFC Mutual Fund, ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund, Nippon India Mutual Fund and HDFC Life Insurance.

Among the largest allocations, HDFC Mutual Fund and ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund received shares worth ₹200 crore each, while Capital World Investors, GIC and LIC were allotted shares worth ₹180 crore each.

Domestic mutual funds accounted for 37 per cent of the anchor book, with 23 investing through 70 schemes. The IPO opened on Tuesday for public subscription, and will close on July 16. The price band has been fixed at ₹545-574 per equity share, with investors able to bid for a minimum of 26 shares and in multiples thereafter.

Caliber Mining and Logistics fixes IPO price band at ₹402-424 per share



Mohit Chadda, CMD, Caliber Mining and Logistics

Chadda and Rahul Roshanlal Chadda.

Of the proceeds from the fresh issue, the company will use ₹208 crore for debt repayment, ₹167 crore for purchase of commercial vehicles, plant and ma-

chinery, and the rest for general corporate purposes. The company has already completed a pre-IPO placement of ₹100 crore.

Incorporated in 2014, Caliber Mining and Logistics is a mining operator managing overburden removal, coal extraction and coal logistics together as an integrated services provider. It has a fleet of 1,911 vehicles, plant and machinery (including 100 that are leased vehicles, plant and machinery) as of April 30.

DAM Capital Advisors will be the Book-Running Lead Manager, while KFin Technologies has been appointed as the Registrar.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 158.95 pts.
	Close(T)	Pts	PE	WN%	
Bharti Airtel	1936.50	23.05	34.89	5.35	
Sun Pharma	1942.60	4.90	40.50	1.87	
ITCS	2200.60	4.26	15.91	2.04	
Apollo Hosp	8890.50	2.65	63.90	0.63	
Hindalco	974.30	2.36	16.35	1.28	
JSW Steel	1247.70	2.11	11.96	1.06	
Tata Steel	188.27	2.09	21.59	1.41	
Adani Ports	1821.90	1.87	32.84	1.22	
Dr Reddys Lab	1246.20	1.56	25.02	0.69	
Eternal LT	286.15	1.50	754.49	1.88	
Cipla	1438.10	1.40	30.08	0.72	
Adani Enter	3188.90	0.72	41.69	0.84	
ONGC	248.90	0.38	6.29	0.88	
Coal India	430.60	0.21	8.54	0.94	
PowerGrid Corp	286.15	0.15	16.71	1.18	
NestleIndia	1427.10	0.02	78.65	0.93	
TataConsumerProduct	1097.60	-0.14	70.22	0.65	
Eicher Motors	7279.50	-0.51	36.23	0.91	
Bharat Elec	410.10	-0.55	49.45	1.33	
Wipro	177.14	-0.81	14.03	0.46	
Asian Paints	2641.00	-1.10	57.64	1.08	
Axis Bank	1317.60	-1.13	15.44	3.44	
SBI Life	1840.30	-1.53	74.73	0.75	
UltraTech Cement	1496.00	-1.94	43.37	1.24	
Hind Unilever	2120.20	-2.02	47.08	1.71	
Max Healthcare	1092.90	-2.16	73.74	0.87	
Trent Ltd.	2689.10	-2.25	28.88	0.74	
Titan	4573.70	-2.51	80.02	1.71	
Grasim Ind	3113.30	-2.55	20.57	1.07	
Tech Mahindra	1484.30	-2.80	30.27	0.80	
ICICI Bank	1407.70	-2.82	17.43	9.16	
NTPC	348.15	-3.73	12.26	1.50	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	235.97	-3.90	99.82	0.70	
Tata Motors PV	333.35	-4.06	4092.24	0.63	
HDFC Life	555.20	-4.28	62.65	0.54	
Bajaj Finserv	1869.20	-4.32	15.38	0.98	
Bajaj Auto	10166.00	-5.20	26.87	1.02	
Reliance Ind	1293.00	-5.75	18.27	7.93	
Maruti Suzuki	13489.00	-5.87	28.89	1.60	
IntiGlobeavi	5108.00	-6.01	0.00	1.05	
Infosys	1092.90	-7.43	15.04	3.48	
ITC	275.55	-8.63	16.43	2.41	
Bajaj Finance	1006.60	-9.37	32.42	2.45	
Kotak Bank	378.65	-9.65	19.53	2.53	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1013.90	-10.46	23.80	1.29	
HCL Tech	1166.70	-12.55	19.01	1.12	
M&M	3093.30	-13.08	20.66	2.51	
State Bank	1019.40	-19.50	10.81	3.81	
L&T	3948.70	-20.40	27.92	1.32	
HDFC Bank	809.40	-28.60	15.74	11.25	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▼ 259.80 pts.

	Close(T)	Pts	PE	WN%
Adani Power .	226.17	130.24	33.63	3.83
Divis Lab	7188.50	93.12	74.31	3.73
AdaniGreenenergy	1604.50	56.99	133.01	2.79
Adani Energy Solutions .	1690.30	43.99	94.86	2.26
Power Finance	409.15	17.28	4.02	2.43
Cg Power & Ind Sol	913.85	16.78	120.27	2.56
Abb India	6892.00	13.07	92.43	1.48
Jindal Steel	1040.10	12.27	31.57	1.57
United Spirits	1386.30	11.17	54.01	1.67
Solar Industries	18287.00	9.35	95.29	1.82
Siemens	3510.30	8.42	81.56	1.27
Torrent Pharma	4973.50	6.89	78.73	2.13
Rural Elec	352.45	5.12	5.69	1.80
VarunBeverages .	470.25	4.61	49.56	2.62
Zyduslisciences	1133.60	1.69	22.26	1.16
Union Bank	170.67	1.59	6.71	1.35
Tata Power	377.70	-0.73	23.58	2.57
Siemens Energy India	3389.60	-3.81	92.16	1.23
Ambuja Cements	429.80	-4.29	19.43	1.09
Shree Cement	26280.00	-5.49	54.22	1.43
Bosch	41460.00	-5.97	44.09	1.47
Indian Railway Finance Corp	88.71	-6.13	16.54	0.77
Hindus Zinc	527.90	-6.62	16.13	1.04
Tata Capital	355.90	-7.45	30.89	0.73
Godrej Consumer	1061.60	-8.36	58.36	1.74
Mazgaon Dock	2359.90	-9.51	34.55	0.73
Vedanta	267.70	-9.69	6.60	1.85
Gail (India)	171.51	-12.73	14.87	1.89
Bpel	305.35	-13.07	5.13	2.52
Muthootfin	3016.40	-13.23	11.42	1.32
Indian Hotels Co.	733.30	-13.51	46.45	2.63
Punjab Natl Bank	105.00	-13.63	6.53	1.48
Hyndal Motor India .	1959.70	-14.70	23.92	1.14
Ltintimreed	4062.80	-16.54	23.19	1.54
Dfl	671.40	-20.49	37.65	1.57
Meta Of India Cv	417.40	-20.51	50.76	3.56
Bank Of Baroda	246.50	-22.02	62.35	1.97
Britannia Ind	5583.50	-22.44	50.16	2.54
Pidlittind	1253.40	-22.98	64.07	1.97
Communis India	5493.50	-24.35	64.48	3.03
Sarnwardmotherinternatnl	142.06	-25.89	36.70	2.56
Indian Oilcorp	137.05	-31.76	44.43	2.09
Oil India	337.75	-33.75	11.92	1.02
Canara Bank	125.74	-35.36	63.8	1.72
Avenuesuper	3911.90	-36.93	83.53	2.57
Industrianaeronautics	4442.40	-38.31	32.59	3.44
Macrotech Developers .	1147.25	-41.79	33.41	1.30
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3608.40	-47.16	53.80	3.46
Cholamandalin&Fin	1771.50	-49.95	28.86	3.13
HdfcAmc	269.80	-53.30	39.89	2.21

QUICKLY.
Ather Energy to unveil mass-market EV scooter

Mumbai: Ather Energy on Tuesday said it will unveil its first mass-market electric scooter, built on the next-generation vehicle architecture, at its flagship event Community Day in Bengaluru on August 29. Alongside the new scooter, Ather said it will also introduce a range of innovations across technology, charging, and the ecosystem that will make the ownership experience more seamless. The scooter is built on the next-generation vehicle architecture, which is the company's first all-new vehicle platform EL since the launch of the 450 platform in 2016. [PTI](#)

Insolvency plea against Simbhaoli Sugar upheld

New Delhi: The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) upheld insolvency proceedings initiated against Simbhaoli Sugar, while dismissing appeals by the company's suspended director and a group of sugarcane farmers. However, a two-member bench has also directed the resolution professional of Simbhaoli Sugar to consider claims filed by sugarcane farmers during the corporate insolvency resolution process. [PTI](#)

Government receives revised financial bids for IDBI Bank

Press trust of India
New Delhi

The government has received revised financial bids for the strategic sale of IDBI Bank from Fairfax Financial Holdings and Emirates NBD, said sources on Tuesday. A final decision on the successful bidder will be taken once the financial bids are opened, which is likely very soon, sources added. According to sources, both bidders have experience in the Indian banking sector, with Dubai-based Emirates NDB acquiring RBL Bank earlier this year and billionaire investor Prem Watsa-backed Fairfax Financial already holding a 40 per cent stake in private sector CSB Bank.

SECURITY CLEARANCE Both bidders already have security clearance from the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) and fit and proper assessment from the RBI. The government and LIC were together looking to sell 60.72 per cent in IDBI Bank and had floated an Expression of Interest (EoI) in October 2022. Financial bids came on February 6. However, the financial bids from Fairfax Financial Holdings and Emirates NBD were below the reserve price decided by the inter-ministerial group on disinvestment headed by secretaries in the Finance Ministry. The government had then put the strategic sale process on hold. The strategic sale process restarted this financial year, and the government, earlier this month, invited revised financial bids from the two suitors. Sources said the financial bids were submitted on Monday, and the bids are yet to be opened. Currently, the government and state-owned LIC together hold a 94.71 per cent stake in IDBI Bank. The government owns 45.48 per cent, and LIC holds 49.24 per cent in the lender. Of this, the government and LIC are looking to sell 60.72 per cent in the bank.

‘Creator economy a key part of India’s digital ecosystem now’

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The creator economy is entering a new phase of growth. What began as a metro-led digital phenomenon has evolved into a geographically distributed and economically significant ecosystem that is reshaping entrepreneurship, marketing and digital commerce across the country. A new report, released by the Indian School of Business’ Sridhi Raju Centre for IT and the Networked Economy and Hashfame, argued that the next phase of India’s creator economy will depend less on expanding participation and more on enabling creators to build sustainable businesses. Titled *Understanding the Canvas of India’s Creator Economy*, the report draws on comprehensive data from the Qoruz Creator Intelligence Platform covering creators, brand campaigns and audience engagement between 2020 and 2025, to examine how India’s creator ecosystem has evolved over the past five years. The findings suggest that the creator

RBI nudges banks to mobilise FCNR (B) deposits, check frauds

THE AGENDA. Calls to increase credit flow, relax gold loan norms in meeting with bankers

Our Bureaus
Mumbai/Chennai

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) used its latest interaction with bank chief executives to push lenders on four areas — strengthening fraud detection mechanisms to tackle mule accounts; accelerating credit growth beyond financial inclusion; improving mobilisation of FCNR(B) deposits and examining relaxation in gold loan norms. FCNR(B) deposit mobilisation emerged as one of the key focus of the meeting, with the RBI seeking explanations from banks on muted inflows despite a sharp rise in deposit rates. FCNR(B) rates have increased from around 3.75 per cent to 6-6.5 per cent, but deposits have not grown proportionately.

FCNR PUSH Governor Sanjay Malhotra urged banks to maximise FCNR(B) deposits, although no formal mobilisation targets were set. The push follows discussions with the Finance Minister and PSU



RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra [REUTERS](#)

bankers on Monday, and is aimed at boosting overseas dollar inflows amid pressure on the rupee. Another banker said the RBI has sought detailed data on FCNR(B) deposits from lenders. Banks estimated that around \$6-8 billion has already been mobilised under the scheme, though markets had expected faster and larger inflows. While NRI interest remains steady, higher funding costs have dampened demand for leveraged products. Lenders also highlighted tax-related challenges. In Singapore, investors face a 10 per cent withholding tax on interest income, reducing

the attractiveness of FCNR (B) deposits. Similar constraints in the US have limited banks’ ability to attract sizeable flows, leaving Hong Kong and Dubai as the most viable markets for deposit mobilisation. Banks further pointed to elevated global funding costs, tighter liquidity and intense competition as factors making overseas fund-raising more difficult. Despite these hurdles, treasury officials remain optimistic that additional FCNR (B) inflows could support the rupee in the coming weeks. The RBI also raised concerns over the growing use of mule accounts in digital

fraud, urging banks to strengthen monitoring and surveillance systems. Lenders were advised to enhance fraud detection capabilities and identify suspicious transactions at an early stage as digital payments continue to expand.

FRAUD PREVENTION The meeting also saw deliberations on whether a brief delay in crediting transactions could help curb payment frauds. While bankers noted that any broad-based delay may be difficult given customers’ expectation of instant payments, a threshold-based approach — allowing instant credits for smaller transactions and introducing a short delay for higher-value transfers — was discussed. Another major theme was the shift from financial inclusion to what RBI officials described as financial expansion. The RBI emphasised the need to increase credit flow to retail borrowers and MSMEs, ensuring that gains from financial inclusion translate into productive lending and economic activity.

RBI to usher in principle-based framework for banks as part of governance overhaul

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The RBI will usher in a principle-based framework for banks, empowering their Boards to delegate routine matters to committees while retaining the ultimate accountability for business strategy, financial soundness and key personnel decisions.

LEVEL PLAYING FIELD This is aimed at enabling the Boards to utilise their time effectively and to facilitate a more focused and qualitative engagement on strategy and risk governance. The RBI’s Amendment Directions on ‘Matters to be placed before the Boards of the Banks’, which are effective from October 1, apply to both public sector banks (PSBs) and private sector banks (PVBs), ensuring a level playing field in governance standards. With this, the central bank is seeking to replace the extant seven broad board agenda themes (business strategy, risk, financial reports and their integrity, compliance, customer protection, financial inclusion and human resources) with



MOVING AHEAD. The objective is to improve Board focus on strategy and risk governance

principle-based guidance (certaining five principles of ultimate responsibility, clear articulation, agenda leadership, information flow and periodic review). The Board has the ultimate responsibility for the bank’s business strategy and financial soundness, key personnel decisions, internal organisation and governance structure and practices; and risk management and compliance obligations, per the directions. It may, however, delegate certain matters to the Board committees/management committees, along with reporting requirements as may be necessary. The Board will be required to clearly articu-

late the matters reserved for its approval, or to be brought to its notice for information or reporting. However, the Board shall ensure that sufficient time is dedicated to strategy and risk governance. **EXTERNAL REPORTS** The RBI said the Chairperson of the Board shall have the primary responsibility for setting the agenda of the meeting. The Board has to ensure that it receives sufficient information from the management to discharge its role effectively. It shall specify the nature and frequency of information required from the management. The Board

Rupee’s weakness worsens

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl research bureau

The rupee came under strong pressure over the past week. The currency depreciated 1.3 per cent to close at 96.20 against the dollar on Tuesday. Notably, the currency lost about 0.6 per cent on Tuesday alone, highlighting the renewed stress in the market.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

The primary trigger has been the re-escalation of tensions involving the US and Iran. Concerns over disruptions to global energy supplies resurfaced after reports that the Strait of Hormuz had once again been blocked, reigniting fears in the oil market. As a result, Brent crude futures, currently trading around \$86 per barrel, rose over 5 per cent last week and are up 13 per cent so far this week. The dollar has also strengthened, benefiting from safe-haven demand as geopolitical uncertainty intensified. The stronger greenback has added to the pressure on emerging market currencies, including the rupee. Domestic macroeconomic indicators are also not offering any relief. India’s trade

deficit widened to \$30.4 billion in June, reflecting elevated import costs. Wholesale inflation also surprised on the upside, with WPI rising to 9.87 per cent in June, compared to market expectations of 9.15 per cent. The wholesale inflation in May was 9.68 per cent. Foreign flows remained positive, with net FPI inflows amounting to about \$1.5 billion over the past week, taking cumulative inflows in July to \$2.7 billion. However, the supportive impact of these flows was overshadowed by rising oil prices and renewed risk aversion. Overall, the fundamental backdrop has turned unfavourable for the rupee. If geopolitical tensions persist and crude prices remain elevated, the pressure on rupee could intensify further.

CHART The rupee slipped below the crucial support at 95.80 on Tuesday and hit a two-month low of 96.24 before closing at 96.20. The price action suggests that the currency may have resumed its broader downturn after the corrective recovery seen in recent weeks. From the current level, the rupee is likely to weaken further towards 96.50. A breach of this level can pave the way for a retest of the all-time low at 96.96. On the other hand, if the currency stages a recovery, it can rise to 95.80, which has now turned into a resistance. A breakout above this can lift it further to 95.40. However, given the prevailing bearish momentum, a sustained move above 95.80 appears less likely. The dollar index, currently hovering around 101, continues to hold above the key support at 100.50. As long as this level remains intact, the broader bias will stay positive. The index also trades above its 21-day and 50-day moving averages, as well as a rising trendline, substantiating the bullish stance. If the dollar index extends its rally from the current level, it can advance towards 102, which could drag the rupee closer to a record low of 96.96. However, a break below 100.50 can weaken the near-term outlook for the dollar and pull the index down to 100. Such a correction may provide room for the rupee to recover above 95.80. The fundamental and technical setup remains unfavourable for the rupee. A sustained rise in the dollar index could drag the currency towards 96.50-96.96, while any recovery is likely to face resistance at 95.80.

RBI to ease bank stake acquisition norms for MFs and insurers

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The RBI plans to simplify the regulatory framework governing acquisition of major shareholding in banks by mutual funds, insurance companies and pension funds. It is likely to introduce a one-time approval mechanism that will allow these institutional investors to increase their stake without seeking repeated regulatory approvals. In this regard, the RBI on Tuesday issued draft amendment directions separately for commercial banks, small finance banks, payments banks and local area banks. This comes in the wake of representations from asset management companies (AMCs) seeking a simpler approval process for subsequent acquisitions after the initial acquisition of a major shareholding in a banking company. **APPROVAL RELIEF** “While obtaining prior approval shall continue to be mandatory for initial acquisition of major shareholding in

a banking company, based on a review, it has now been decided to grant one-time approval for subsequent acquisitions of major shareholding in the same banking company by mutual funds, insurance companies and pension funds, subject to certain requirements,” per the draft amendment directions. According to the extant master directions, if a person’s aggregate shareholding, after the initial acquisition of a major shareholding, falls below five per cent at any point in time, prior RBI approval has to be obtained again before any subsequent acquisition of a major shareholding. Further, any person seeking to acquire a major shareholding — defined as an aggregate holding of 5 per cent or more of a bank’s paid-up share capital or voting rights — is required to obtain prior approval from the RBI. The RBI has now proposed to remove this recurring approval requirement for mutual funds, insurance companies and pension funds by introducing a one-time approval framework.

Hydrogen-powered trucks and buses get 7-year permit exemption given to EVs, ethanol vehicles

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Commercial-vehicle makers, including Tata Motors, Ashok Leyland and VE Commercial Vehicles, could benefit from the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways’ (MoRTH) decision to bring hydrogen-powered transport vehicles under the same seven-year permit-exemption framework as battery-electric, ethanol- and methanol-powered vehicles. The July 2026 notification exempts qualifying vehicles from permits required under Section 66(1) of the Motor Vehicles Act, subject to the installation of AIS-140-compliant vehicle-location tracking systems.

LESS FRICTION The move could reduce administrative friction, improve fleet utilisation and strengthen the operating case for alternative-fuel trucks and buses without directly subsidising vehicle purchases. Hydrogen is the principal new beneficiary as India’s clean commercial vehicle transition moves beyond



SMOOTH DRIVE. The move could reduce administrative friction, improve fleet utilisation and boost operations

purchase incentives towards easing operating regulations for cleaner trucks and buses.

TRACKING DEVICES The notification states that “transport vehicles powered by battery, methanol, ethanol and hydrogen” will be exempt from the provisions of Section 66(1) of the Motor Vehicles Act for seven years from the date of publication of the notification in the Official Gazette, provided they are fitted with AIS-140-compliant vehicle-location tracking devices and subsequent amendments thereof. Importantly, the seven-year exemption period begins from the date of Gazette publication, rather than from the purchase date of in-

dividual vehicles. The relief is limited to permit requirements under Section 66(1). Registration, road tax, tolls, fitness certification, insurance, driver licensing requirements and local operating restrictions will continue to apply. For logistics companies, private bus operators and corporate fleet owners, the exemption could shorten deployment timelines by reducing paperwork linked to permit applications, renewals and route- or area-specific approvals. **PERMITS TO UTILISATION** Industry experts say the larger benefit is likely to come not from savings on permit fees, but from improved

vehicle utilisation. Gurusharan Dhillion, an expert in hydrogen and electric mobility, said rigid permit structures can penalise operators seeking greater routing flexibility. He cited the example of a clean-fuel bus being used for school transportation during the day and employee transportation services in the evening, subject to applicable safety and operating regulations. “If sustainable-fuel vehicle fleets demonstrate that they can operate safely and efficiently under digital monitoring without needing traditional route permits, it may build a compelling case for a permanent, nationwide shift in how India regulates commercial transport,” he said. The notification also reflects a shift from paper-based permissions towards digital traceability and monitoring. Mandatory AIS-140 tracking allows authorities to retain visibility over vehicle movement while giving manufacturers an opportunity to integrate telematics, compliance and fleet-management services into their offerings.

QUICKLY.

Gold gains after soft US inflation data



Gold gained more than two per cent on Tuesday after softer than expected inflation data boosted hopes of the US Federal Reserve adopting a less hawkish stance. Spot gold rose 2.1 per cent to \$4,083.99 per ounce by 1249 GMT. US gold futures gained 2.2 per cent to \$4,091.80. Silver rose 2.2 per cent to \$58.89. REUTERS

Palm oil extends gains on stronger crude oil

Jakarta: Malaysian palm oil futures climbed for a second straight session, underpinned by strength in rival edible oils in the Chicago and Dalian markets, while higher crude oil prices also lent support. The benchmark palm oil contract for September delivery on the BMD gained 40 ringgit to 4,573 ringgit a tonne. REUTERS

Copper hits 3-week high on China tightness



London: Copper prices extended gains to touch their strongest in three weeks on signs of firmer demand and shortages in China, as well as supply worries after more attacks in West Asia. Benchmark three month copper on the LME climbed 0.4 per cent to \$13,590 a tonne. Aluminium edged down to \$3,167, and tin jumped three per cent to \$54,195. REUTERS

Go long on aluminium

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

Aluminium prices have recovered well over the last week. The aluminium futures contract traded on the Multi Commodity Exchange touched a low of ₹325 per kg in the beginning of this month. From there, it has risen over 5 per cent and is currently trading at ₹343.

COMMODITY CALL.

The recent rise looks just like a corrective bounce within the broader downtrend. Immediate support is in the ₹340-₹335 region. As long as the contract trades above this support zone, more rise is possible. The contract could rise to ₹350-₹352 from here.

The region between ₹350 and ₹352 is a good resistance zone, where the corrective rise could halt. A reversal from this resistance zone

Centre set to ban Paraquat herbicide, issues draft order

PRESSING AHEAD. Final notification is likely to be issued after August 12 by the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The government on Tuesday issued a draft order proposing a blanket ban on Paraquat Dichloride, citing its severe toxicity to humans and animals. The draft notification seeks to halt the manufacture, import, sale and distribution of the widely used herbicide, giving stakeholders 30 days to submit feedback before a final ban is gazetted.

Already outlawed in more than 70 countries, Paraquat Dichloride is linked to fatal poisoning, kidney failure, lung fibrosis and Parkinson’s disease. However, the proposed ban faces a massive commercial footprint at home, where a vast agro-

chemical market includes more than 1,500 manufacturers holding licences for the chemical.

The Union Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare had constituted an expert committee in January to examine the continued use of Paraquat Dichloride in India. After detailed examination, the panel submitted its report on June 12.

businessline in May reported that the panel unanimously agreed to recommend a nationwide ban on Paraquat.

SEVERAL CONCERNS
Acting on the expert panel’s suggestions, the Registration Committee, headed by Agriculture Commissioner PK Singh, on June 29 submitted its views.



SLOW MOVE. The Centre’s action comes amid growing pressure from States such as Telangana and Odisha, which have already imposed temporary curbs

The Registration Committee has identified several areas of concern, including documented adverse health effects, continued history of poisoning incidents and reported high fatalities, and the absence of a specific anti-

dote among many others.

The committee recommended a complete prohibition of Paraquat Dichloride in India under the Insecticides Act, 1968.

After duly considering the report of the Registration

Committee, the Central government is satisfied that “the use of Paraquat Dichloride insecticide is likely to involve risk to human beings and animals as to render it expedient or necessary to take immediate action.”

The draft order said that the ban “shall come into force on the date of its final publication in the official gazette” after which no person shall be allowed to import, manufacture, sell, transport, distribute and use Paraquat Dichloride.

The Registration Committee will also call back the certificate of registrations granted for Paraquat Dichloride from all the manufacturers, and the certificate shall be deemed to be cancelled from the date of final publication of the order.

The Centre’s move, though slow, comes amid growing pressure from States such as Telangana and Odisha, which have already imposed temporary restrictions and sought permanent intervention by the Centre.

DOMESTIC SALES UP

On the other hand, the ban could significantly alter weed-management practices across cereals, plantation crops and horticulture, and also increase cultivation costs for farmers dependent on chemical weed control.

Paraquat is extensively used in tea, rubber, coffee, cotton, paddy, wheat, maize, potato, grapes and apple cultivation, besides weed control in canals, ponds and waterways.

Its low cost and rapid ac-

tion have made it one of the preferred non-selective herbicides in Indian agriculture.

Trade data indicate that dependence on the herbicide continued despite safety concerns. Imports rose from 8,598 tonnes in 2019-20 to 20,786 tonnes in 2022-23. Domestic sales, after declining to 74,490 tonnes in 2020-21 from 1.13 lakh tonnes in 2019-20, recovered to 1.05 lakh tonnes in 2023-24.

Telangana banned the sale, distribution and use of Paraquat for 60 days from April 1, the maximum period that States are empowered to impose curbs under existing rules. Earlier attempts by Kerala to sustain curbs were struck down by courts on the grounds that States cannot impose an indefinite ban.

Edible oil imports down 30% in June as palm, soy oil shipments fall

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

A decline in the import of palm oil and soybean oil led to a reduction in total edible oil shipments into India in June 2026. Per the Solvent Extractors’ Association of India (SEA), India imported 11.11 lakh tonnes (lt) of edible oil in June 2026 against 15.97 lt in June 2025, registering a decline of 30 per cent. BV Mehta, Executive Director of SEA, said the decline was primarily driven by a collapse in palm oil demand to 4.87 lt in June 2026 against 5.46 lt in May 2026 and 9.52 lt in June 2025.

He said soybean oil imports declined to 3.80 lt in June 2026 from 4.93 lt in May 2026. This decline was caused by the vanishing price

discount of palm oil against soft oils (like soy), which dropped to under \$50 a tonne, he said.

He said the drop in Indian buying is a ripple effect of simultaneous biofuel mandates introduced by Indonesia, Malaysia and the US, which are pulling millions of tonnes of vegoils out of the food economy and into the fuel economy, driving up global spot prices.

Despite a decline in edible oil imports in June, cumulative imports during the first eight months of the oil year 2025-26 (November-October) remained higher than the corresponding period of the previous year.

India imported 103.88 lt of edible oil during November-June of the oil year 2025-26 against 97.29 lt in the corresponding period of the previ-

ous oil year, registering a growth of 7 per cent.

IMPORT FROM NEPAL

Imports of refined oils from Nepal continued at significant levels. Nepal exported approximately 3.38 lt of refined oils to India during November-April 2025-26. This included 2.97 lt of refined soybean oil, 19,911 tonnes of refined sunflower oil, 18,295 tonnes of RBD palmolein and 3,081 tonnes of rapeseed oil.

Nepal’s refined oil exports to India were estimated at around 54,000 tonnes in May and 32,000 tonnes in June, consisting mainly of refined soybean oil, along with smaller quantities of sunflower oil and RBD palmolein.

Nepal enjoys nil import duty under the SAFTA agreement for exports to India.

Fresh ‘low’ over Bay to revive monsoon

Vinson Kurian
Thiruvananthapuram

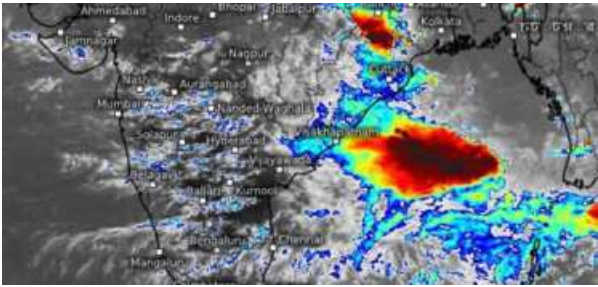
A fresh low-pressure area, only the second of the season, is set to form over the north Bay of Bengal and the adjoining West Bengal-Bangladesh coast by Tuesday, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said on Monday.

The system is expected to revive the monsoon after its current weak phase.

RAINFALL RETREATS

During this weak spell, rainfall has largely retreated from most parts of the country, persisting mainly over East and North-East India and stretches of the East Coast, including Odisha, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. Ironically, this “break-like” phase is itself nearing an end.

An upper-air cyclonic cir-



MAKING A COMEBACK. A brewing low-pressure area on Tuesday is bringing back monsoon clouds and heavy rain (in dark red) off the Andhra Pradesh coast

ulation has already formed over the north Bay and adjoining south Bangladesh, a favourable location for spawning a low-pressure system.

TROUGH BENDS TO SEA

While the circulation has so far channelled rainfall mainly into East and North-East India, the anticipated low is expected to broaden the reach of the monsoon.

Another sign of revival came from the seasonal monsoon trough, the atmospheric spine of the monsoon. On Monday, it extended from Jammu through Dehradun (Uttarakhand), Barabanki (Uttar Pradesh), Patna (Bihar), Bankura and Canning (West Bengal), before dipping into the east-central Bay.

Over the past several days, the eastern end of the trough

has remained over the plains and locked against the Himalayan foothills, a classic indicator of a weak monsoon.

WEST PACIFIC CHURN

The monsoon trough’s southward shift over the Bay, along with the formation of a low-pressure area, is set to revive monsoon activity across wider regions. The spread of the revival, however, will hinge on the strength, track, intensity and lifespan of the system.

The system traces its origins to weather disturbances over the western Pacific. Typhoon Bavi, after skirting Taiwan and crossing southern China, helped energise the region before moving towards the Korean Peninsula.

Tropical storm Haishen was also active east of the Philippines on Monday, sustaining the chain of disturbances that often spawn Bay low-pressure systems.

Mpeda to start fresh chilled fish exports to the UK

Our Bureau
Kochi

To commemorate the entry into force of the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), the Marine Products Export Development Authority (Mpeda), Sub-Regional Division, Thoothukudi, is set to flag off fresh chilled fish consignments from the Thiruvananthapuram International Airport.

Mpeda officials said the consignment, exported by Gladson Exporters and Jude Foods India Pvt Ltd, would be around 2,000 kg.

Johnson D’Cruz, Deputy Director, Mpeda SRD Thoothukudi, said the India-UK CETA marks a milestone for India’s seafood export sector. During 2025-26, India’s seafood exports to the UK reached 18,898 tonnes, valued at \$128.20 million.

NCDEX to launch guar korma futures

Our Bureau
Chennai

NCDEX will launch guar korma futures from July 24, providing exporters, processors and cattle-feed manufacturers a regulated hedge for the commodity, in which India makes up 80 per cent of the global production.

The country is a leading shipper of guar korma, which is a byproduct obtained from the germ part of guarseeds, to Europe’s dairy belt. Guar is commonly known as cluster beans.

The contracts in the futures will expire from September 2026 to January 2027. Further expiries will be in line with the exchange’s launch calendar, said a NCDEX statement.

The contract will be ex-warehouse Jodhpur with a trading unit of 5 tonnes, and it will have to be compulsorily delivered on expiry.

The statement said the exchange will bring the same



institutional rigour that it applies to guarseed and guar gum futures. Guar korma has not been hedged until now.

MANAGING PRICE RISKS

Kedar Deshpande, NCDEX Chief Business Officer, said the price risk of guar korma, which plays a crucial role in the animal feed industry as a high-protein feed ingredient, has been entirely not managed.

“For exporters shipping to Europe on extended timelines, the gap between

contracting a price and delivering the cargo is where the real risk sits. A transparent futures market lets them close that gap. It also strengthens price transmission back to the farm gate, connecting guar growers in Rajasthan, Gujarat and Haryana more directly to the value being created downstream in this export chain,” he said.

Guar korma has never had an organised, exchange-based platform for price discovery and risk until now, the statement said.

Its price is determined by an unusually layered set of forces — domestic guar processing economics (the split between guar gum, guar korma and guar churi yields), competing protein substitutes such as soymeal and cottonseed oil cake in domestic as well as international feed markets, and demand cycles in the dairy, poultry, fishery and piggery industries of the importing nations.

‘Don’t make India a dumping ground for aluminium scrap’

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Aluminium Association of India (AAI) has urged the Ministries of Finance and Mines to prevent India from becoming a “dumping ground” for low-grade aluminium scrap.

A statement from the AAI said aluminium is no longer a conventional metal, but a future-facing strategic material used across power, transport, infrastructure, defence, aerospace, packaging, electronics, utensils and renewable energy.

BALANCED APPROACH

“Any unchecked entry of aluminium scrap can therefore have a wider economic impact by affecting product quality, consumer safety, manufacturing competitiveness and the credibility of India’s aluminium value chain,” it said.

Calling for a balanced response that protects genuine recycling operations while curbing low-grade dumping, it said immediate fiscal interventions could be undertaken by maintaining basic customs duty (BCD) on aluminium scrap at 2.5 per cent. This could be till the government publishes the pending BIS scrap quality standards and introduces grade-wise HSN codes so that high-quality scrap is clearly separated from inferior grades, it said.

In its submissions, the AAI said global economies were tightening their aluminium value chains by increasing tariffs and non-tariff barriers on Chapter 76. Also, they promote export of low-quality aluminium scrap (less than 90% aluminium content) while retaining high quality scrap in their country. This is leading to global aluminium surplus and low-quality aluminium scrap being dumped in India.

Industree Foundation, Nagaland agency partner to boost women-led bamboo livelihoods

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

In a move to advance regenerative, women-led livelihoods, Industree Foundation, a non-profit working at the intersection of equity, climate and gender, has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Nagaland State Rural Livelihoods Mission (NS-RLM) in Kohima.

Under the partnership, NSRLM, with Industree Foundation as its technical and knowledge partner, will integrate 30,000 smallholder women farmers into the bamboo value chain and help establish women-led collective enterprises.

The initiative is part of the DAY-NRLM’s Bamboo Sub-Sector Initiative under the Ministry of Rural Develop-

ment, which aims to empower one million rural women over the next four to five years through bamboo cultivation and stronger market linkages.

The collaboration combines Industree’s ecosystem-led approach with NS-RLM’s institutional reach to strengthen climate-resilient, income-generating livelihoods for rural women in Nagaland.

The MoU was signed by Moa Sangtam, Joint Secretary, RD and Mission Director, NSRLM, in the presence of senior officials from NSRLM and Industree Foundation, including CEO Neju George Abraham.

MARKET POTENTIAL

“Bamboo is deeply rooted in Nagaland’s everyday life and culture. The State’s remarkable diversity of bamboo spe-



cies also holds strong commercial potential. Through this partnership, in addition to developing certified plantations and enabling carbon credit accreditation, we look forward to building and strengthening processing capabilities in the State by establishing processing units, developing new products and connecting produ-

cers to high-value markets. Nagaland’s unique bamboo resources have the potential to create new opportunities, strengthen the bamboo sector in India and take Indian bamboo to global markets,” said Abraham.

INCOME SECURITY

Over the past few years, Industree Foundation has enabled predominantly women smallholder farmers to cultivate bamboo on fallow and unutilised land, improving incomes while addressing climate challenges.

Farmers begin earning from the fourth year of harvest, with bamboo yielding for over 40 years, providing long-term income security.

The foundation follows a seed-to-market approach, building traceable supply chains for the domestic and global markets.

Transform Rural India helps M.P. women earn more

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Until five years ago, Muliya Kumhare, a smallholder farmer from remote and underdeveloped Pipariya Maal village in Mandla district, Madhya Pradesh, earned a meagre income through subsistence farming.

A training and support initiative from not-for-profit Transform Rural India (TRI) helped her transform agricultural practices, adopt scientific methods and organic inputs, such as *jeevamrit* (a fully natural and fermented organic fertilizer and soil activator), cow dung compost, and neem-based pest management.

What began as a small intervention in vegetable farming has turned into a complete livelihood shift — from uncertainty to empowerment, from subsist-



LIFTING WOMEN FARMERS. A training and support initiative from TRI helped transform agricultural practices, and adopt scientific methods and organic inputs

ence to sustainability, with TRI’s help.

AN INSPIRATION

Her transformation, which now earns her more than ₹2 lakh a year, has become an inspiration for other women in the village, who have begun undergoing similar training and cultivation, said a statement from the not-for-profit organisation.

With improved soil health, higher yields and

poultry farming as a secondary income source, Kumhare now cultivates over 2.5 acres and earns a stable livelihood. Her journey highlights the direct link between plant health, sustainable farming and rural resilience.

But it came with its own problems. TRI said initially, Muliya had little awareness of scientific cultivation methods, inputs or seasonal crop planning, as she relied on traditional practices.

She was initially hesitant to adopt new methods. Once convinced, she decided to undergo training. The training introduced her to improved techniques such as line sowing, crop rotation and the use of *machaan* (a traditional elevated platform) structures for climbing vegetables.

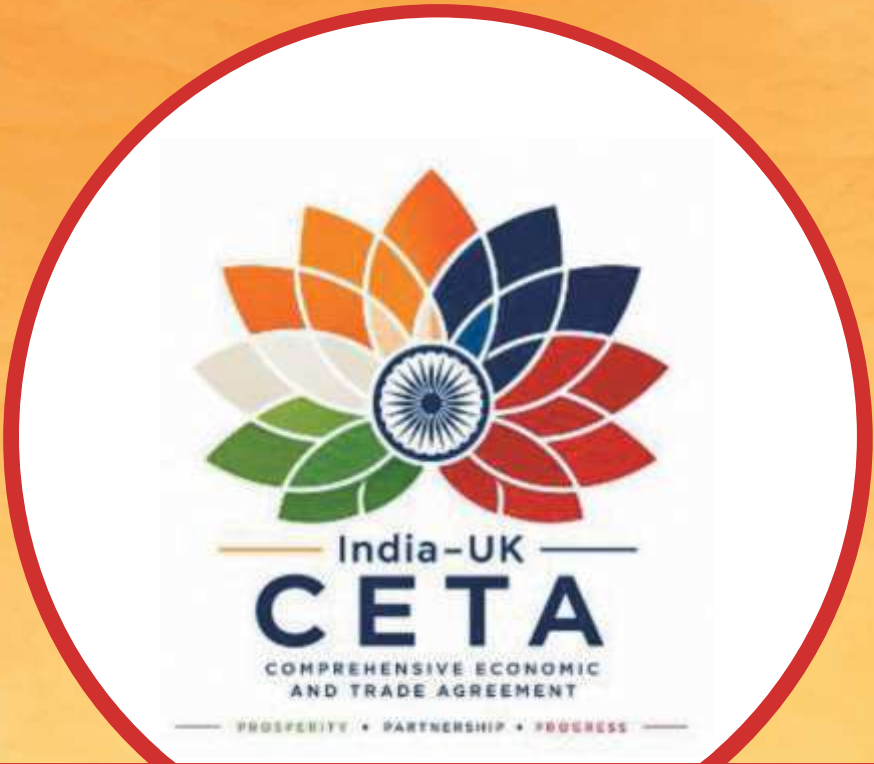
She was provided with a *machaan* kit by TRI. It became the starting point for her transformation. Gaining confidence, Kumhare began to expand the area under cultivation.

She expressed interest in diversifying her income, and started poultry farming. Today, she maintains 650 chicks and gets an income of ₹75,000 a year.

Kumhare is viewed as a role model by other women in her village, many of whom visit her farm and seek advice on *machaan* building, poultry farming and organic composting.



Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



Devendra Fadnavis
Chief Minister

Ceremonial Inauguration of India-UK CETA

Chief Guest
Devendra Fadnavis
Chief Minister
(Government of Maharashtra)

in the august presence of

Eknath Shinde
Deputy Chief Minister
(Government of Maharashtra)

Sunetra Ajit Pawar
Deputy Chief Minister
(Government of Maharashtra)

Hosted By
Uday Samant
Minister of Industries and
Marathi Language
(Government of Maharashtra)

Jaykumar Rawal
Minister of Marketing and Protocol
(Government of Maharashtra)

in coordination with
British Deputy High Commission, Mumbai

Venue
BALLROOM, Taj Colaba

Date & Time
15th July 2026 at 4.30 PM

**‘Maharashtra’ - Powering
the India-UK CETA Growth Story**

MAHARASHTRA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION
(A Government of Maharashtra Undertaking)

Shanghai: AstraZeneca will pay Dical Pharmaceutical \$600 million upfront for global rights to one of its lung cancer drugs, the Chinese drugmaker said in a filing to the Shanghai stock exchange on Tuesday. REUTERS

Google is also enabling Indian enterprises, including regulated industries and the public sector, to run Gemini on Google Distributed Cloud from within Indian



WINNING TRUST

Addressing the media, Richard Seroter, Chief Evangelist, Google Cloud, said, "India is one of our hottest markets and has one of our largest developer populations. There is also growth in

“People will pick the right model for the right thing.”

“Some of the small Gemma models sit on phones and are embedded in Chrome on desktop. Some of these small models can be fine-tuned for specific use cases, like healthcare, education, or legal. We will keep investing here. One doesn’t always need a trillion parameters. Sometimes, you just need a model that can run locally,” he highlighted.



He added that while there is no reason for widespread panic, complacency should also be avoided.

